

# thunk

*About 420 words, roughly three minutes at a calm pace. Pause where the paragraphs break; do not rush the last line.*

I taught myself to build a little RPG on a graphing calculator in the honor block of a maximum security prison. Later I worked through a whole JavaScript book on a locked-down library computer, because that was the only machine I was allowed to touch. Nobody handed me a curriculum. I put it together out of scraps. I want to build the thing that would have met me where I was.

Here is the problem. Almost every coding program for people like me teaches web development. The Last Mile teaches JavaScript. Justice Through Code teaches Python. Good programs, and I respect them. But web development is the most crowded corner of the whole industry, and it is shrinking. And I could not find a single prison or reentry program that teaches systems, or embedded, or kernel work. Not one. There is a reason it is empty: that kind of work usually needs hardware, and hardware does not clear a prison review.

So I am building thunk. It is one small program, written in Rust, that runs completely offline on a locked-down laptop. No internet, no install. It teaches how a computer actually works, from true zero, at your own pace. And it ends with DOOM, the game, booting on a screen you learned to drive from the bare metal up. The whole low-level stack is simulated in software, so you reach that finish line with no hardware at all. The thing that kept everyone else out, I designed around.

But here is the part that matters most for reentry. thunk does not end with a certificate. It ends with a portfolio you can actually point to. You write a real driver. And then, once you are home, you make your first real contribution to open source. That one is everything, because a merged contribution is public, it is permanent, and it does not ask about your record. When a background check might quietly close a door, open source is a door that is already open, and nobody can take it back. The review judges your code, not your past.

I am not pitching this from the sidelines. I am building the exact capstone it teaches toward, right now, myself, on real hardware. And the first phase is already built and passing tests. I can show it running today.

**What I am asking for is a yes, and the room to build it. Because this is what I believe we are actually doing here: compiling a bright future, through open source.**

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#### DELIVERY

**0:00–0:30** the calculator / honor-block hook — slow, plain, let it sit. **0:30–1:05** the problem — land “Not one.” **1:05–1:50** what thunk is — the DOOM line is the hook; pause after it. **1:50–2:35** reentry + open source — the heart; slow down on “does not ask about your record.” **2:35–3:00** why me + the ask — end on the last line, add nothing after it.